Night Vision

By Dominique Morisseau

NOTE: To be performed by 2 black actors

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Stereotypes are the belief that most members of a group have the same characteristics.*
ACTRESS: *For example, ALL white women are "Karens"*
ACTOR: *Or ALL police officers like donuts.*
ACTRESS: *Or ALL black men are criminals. Ultimately these stereotypes dehumanize the individual and lead to actions and reactions based on these biased beliefs.*
ACTOR: *Now none of us want to admit to being biased . . . not externally anyway.*
ACTRESS: *But biases do exist. Call them internal, implicit or unconscious . . . even people who strive not to be are biased.*
ACTOR: *No matter how diligently we aspire not to judge others "by the color of their skin, but by the content of their character," we struggle to attain this ideal.*
ACTRESS: *Ok, Ok . . . I can admit, "Karen's" are funny, and donut-loving police officers are harmless, but I **can't** be biased against black people. (beat) I'm black.*
TOGETHER: *Night Vision by Dominique Morisseau*

(Lights up on the living room of a Brooklyn apartment. Somewhere, importantly: a black hooded sweatshirt. AYANNA, pregnant, enters with her husband EZRA)

AYANNA: **(Pg 15-21)** I cannot believe that. I'm still shaking.

EZRA: Sit down baby.

AYANNA: I don't want to sit down. I want to find him and kick his ass. I want to – Aren't you upset?

EZRA: I'm a lot of things.

AYANNA: I'm hurt. I'm angry. I'm disgusted. I have to pee. I want to find him and kick his ass.

EZRA: You're not going back out there, baby.

AYANNA: Then you should go out there.

EZRA: I should go back out there??? You want me to go out there and kick his ass?

AYANNA: Maybe.

EZRA: What if he has a gun? *(Beat)*

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AYANNA: It was like . . . was he punching on her?

EZRA: I couldn't really see. Could you?

AYANNA: Not completely.

EZRA: Me neither. *(A moment)* I should've kicked his ass. I hesitated.

AYANNA: I'm calling the police.

EZRA: Yeah?

AYANNA: What else can I do?

EZRA: You? Nothing. Me? I can go find him.

AYANNA: No. You're not a vigilante. I don't want you hunting anyone. What if you become the prey?

EZRA: Then call the cops.

AYANNA: I'm calling the cops. *(AYANNA pulls out her cell. EZRA peers out of the window)*

EZRA: *(almost to himself)* It's the darkness out there. You could get swallowed by it. Damn busted streetlight. Been half a year and they haven't fixed it.

AYANNA: *(into the phone)* Hi, yes, I want to report a situation I just witnessed. A man was beating his girlfriend. She was screaming and he - Yes. Yes, I'm sure he was beating her. I'm sure. And she was screaming and then he took off and ran down the block - Yes. Yes, okay. He was a ... he was wearing a hooded sweatshirt. It was covering his face, but I think it was red. Yes. And his pants were dipped low . . . um . . . below his waist. He had on sneakers. He took off running toward Marcy and Green. You could still catch him if you hurry. He was a ... young . . . Black -

EZRA: Wait, baby - hold on now. Are you sure???

AYANNA: *(cupping the phone)* What? *(into the phone)* Yes, I'm still here. Give me a sec.

EZRA: He was Black?

AYANNA: Yes, I'm sure. My memory is ... I'm sure.

EZRA: Are you??? Cuz I'm not. I thought the sweatshirt was green.

AYANNA: It was red.

EZRA: Are you sure?

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AYANNA: Yes! I'm - shit, I'm sure! *(into the phone)* Yes, he ran on foot. We screamed and he ran on foot. My husband yelled. Scared him off. She um, the girl ran too. Into a home. Yes, sure. Okay. Thank you. Uh, no." Anonymous please. Yes. No problem. *(AYANNA hangs up. She looks at EZRA)* You trying to freak me out?

EZRA: I don't remember red.

AYANNA: Ezra, are you kidding me? The sweatshirt was . . .

EZRA: . . . green, Ayanna. It was green.

AYANNA: Was it? No. That's not right. How could that be right? The streetlight near him wasn't even working. He was in the shadows. I remember red because when he ran, he fell into some headlights for a second. I remember thinking he looked like the devil.

EZRA: I remember green. I remember thinking when he fell into that pool of light that he looked pale underneath all that green. That's what I remember thinking.

AYANNA: Could hardly see his face. It was too dark.

EZRA: Then how did you know he was Black?

AYANNA: I... *(A moment)* What's happening right now? I called the cops. Was I not supposed to call the cops?

EZRA: No. You can call the cops. You did. You called the cops.

AYANNA: So then what's with the - I mean, why are you doubting me?

EZRA: I'm not doubting you, baby. I'm questioning you. Big difference.

AYANNA: But what in the - what for?

EZRA: Because you aren't sure. For this you have to be. It costs too much to be wrong.

AYANNA: No, I was sure. I was sure. I felt sure.

EZRA: But you aren't. *(Beat)*

AYANNA: I can't sit still. I'm going to shake myself into oblivion.

EZRA: Sit down. You're upset. You're moving too much. Just sit down.

AYANNA: Hypothyroidism. It's a risk. All my books say so. Not good for the baby. *(shift)* I'm all confused now.

EZRA: You're not helping anything right now, Ayanna.

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AYANNA: I'm not helping? I tried to help. You told me I was wrong.

EZRA: I didn't-- I didn't say you were wrong. I just asked if you were sure.

AYANNA: Dammit Ezra! How am I supposed to be sure??? It's dark.

EZRA: It's nighttime. It's supposed to be dark. Now a brother is a hazard if he walks around at night? Should we carry a label? Caution. Objects appear darker than they really are.

AYANNA: I don't know. Someone was beating a woman. Someone was beating on a woman!!! What am I supposed to do? What if that wasn't his girlfriend? What if he was trying to rape her? What if you hadn't yelled and I hadn't screamed from a distance for him to STOP? What if he beat her to death? Should I not have - should I not try to send the police after him? Should I not have tried to describe him like I remember?

EZRA: Even if your memory is blurred? Even if it's clouded with emotion? Not for one second did I look at that man and think he was Black. Or even young. He was buried in clothing. I didn't know what race he was. He was a blur of half a man. A colorless half a man.

AYANNA: That belongs in jail.

EZRA: That maybe needed some help.

AYANNA: Needed some help?

EZRA: Maybe was homeless and insane or on drugs or high. Maybe was desperate and trying to rob her. Maybe was a kid in trouble - misguided. Maybe -

AYANNA: Maybe was an asshole that needed to be locked away.

EZRA: Maybe. *(Beat)*

AYANNA: I'm going to make some tea. Do you want some tea?

EZRA: No.

AYANNA: Are you ... are you upset? With me?

EZRA: No. I'm just- no.

AYANNA: I thought he was. He looked like - the way he was dressed. I didn't even consider that he wasn't. Until you got me confused. I didn't even consider for a second.

EZRA: That's the itch right there. That you didn't even consider - there was no possibility of it being another - in your mind, we're the default. How are we your default?

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AYANNA: Ezra, I'm on your team. You know that, right? You and me, husband and wife. I wouldn't -- We're going to have a son. I'm on your side. I'm also one of "us." I wouldn't-

EZRA: I know.

AYANNA: Ethno-cultural empathy.

EZRA: What?

AYANNA: In my reading. You're more likely to have empathy for someone who looks like you. Shares your same background. Walked a mile in your shoes. You're concerned about the brother. Concerned that he may be getting a bad rap. I get it. Meanwhile you haven't said one thing about the woman. Even wondered if she was ok.

EZRA: That's what you think of me? That I don't care about her? That I wasn't worried about her getting the life knocked out of her? Why do you think I yelled?

AYANNA: Why didn't you chase him?

EZRA: And what should I have done with you? Leave you? In the middle of Green Ave in the dark? Pregnant and alone? That's the man you want to have a child with?

AYANNA: No. *(Beat)*

EZRA: I need to take a walk.

AYANNA: You're going to leave? While I'm emotional???

EZRA: No baby, not leaving. Just stepping out. Need some air. Come back. Rub your feet. Draw you a bath. Okay? *(EZRA grabs his hooded sweatshirt.)*

AYANNA: You're not going to -- You're not going to wear that.

EZRA: It's getting chilly out there.

AYANNA: Not tonight. Not tonight.

EZRA: It's all I have. This and a winter coat. I'm supposed to carry that weight now? It's supposed to be my burden to change my attire now?

AYANNA: You're going to make me insane.

EZRA: I'm just going to take a walk, baby. Come back. Put you to bed. Just wanna go make sure everything is okay out there. That's all. You stay here. Rest. *(EZRA heads to the door. Looks at AYANNA)* Listen ...if you're sure, then I trust you. I stand by what you saw. *(He walks*

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over. Kisses her on the forehead and leaves) (A moment. She peers out of the window.) (Flash of police car lights. Sirens.) (Suddenly a kick in her stomach. Intuition. She grabs her belly urgently.)

AYANNA: Oh God . . . I'm not sure . . . *(She holds her breath - hands over her heart)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2020 National Qualifier
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